

HEMANT CHAWLA

HERALDING THE UPA ERA
Manmohan Singh with Congress president Sonia Gandhi after the declaration of the Lok Sabha poll results, May 19, 2004

During his 10 years as PM, 138 million people were pulled out of poverty. Primary school enrolment shot up, life expectancy improved and India was declared polio-free

WELCOMING CRITICISM

In 2012, an array of superstar guests, including cabinet ministers, bankers, industrialists, senior editors, economists, lawyers and civil servants had gathered in a conference room in New Delhi's Vigyan Bhavan. The occasion was the launch of a second edition of a festschrift for Dr Manmohan Singh titled *India's Economic Reforms and Development: Essays for Manmohan Singh*, edited by Isher and Ian Little (his thesis advisor at Oxford). A distinguished panel including Raghuram Rajan from the Chicago School of Business, was slated to discuss the challenges of economic reforms in India. PM Manmohan Singh was the chief guest. The mood was sombre. Economic growth had slowed down to 5.8 per cent in the last quarter of 2011-12 and inflation was high. Regulatory delays were holding up the implementation of large projects. The Supreme Court had cancelled the 2G licences barely two months earlier and a draft of the CAG's report on coal block allocation had just leaked to the press.

Isher initiated the discussion by flagging the slowdown and highlighting the need for corrective action. Raghuram Rajan was the star performer. He began by saying that India's economic reforms had achieved a great deal, but things were going wrong. Growth was slowing down, but the politicians, instead of responding with more reforms, were trying to buy popularity by increasing subsidies and transfers. He warned against the 'resource raj', which allowed businessmen to use political connections to get access to natural resources. It says something about Manmohan Singh that despite the very critical stance of Raghuram Rajan's presentation, he was appointed four months later as chief economic advisor in the Ministry of Finance. Isher pointed out to me that by doing so, Dr Singh was living up to the *doha* (verse) from Sant Kabir which says, *Nindak niyare rakhiye, aangan kuti chawai, Bin pani, sabun bina, nirmal kare subhai* (Keep your critic close to you; give him shelter in your courtyard, without soap and water, he will cleanse your character).

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HUMILITY PERSONIFIED

Manmohan Singh never bragged about his achievements. He genuinely believed it was best to let the results speak for themselves. But because neither he, nor his party, projected these achievements, they never formed part of the political discourse. I saw this for myself in 2013, when the Congress seemed unable or unwilling to claim credit for a decline in poverty in India, which was being widely acclaimed as a major achievement in the rest of the world.

Public memory is short and it was no surprise that towards the end of UPA 2, the achievements of the first seven years were forgotten and the narrative was dominated by the economic slowdown, a sense of paralysis in decision-making and the continuously repeated charges of corruption. At his last press conference, Manmohan Singh was asked what he thought about his tenure. With characteristic modesty, he said he had done the best he could: 'History will judge me more kindly than the press does today.' I have no doubt he will be proven right. However, I reminded him that in saying so, he was quoting Winston Churchill. But Churchill had gone on to explain that history would judge him more kindly because he intended to write it himself! I have often urged Dr Manmohan Singh to write his memoirs but had no such luck. ■

Excerpts from* Backstage: The Story Behind India's High Growth Years *by Montek Singh Ahluwalia have been reproduced courtesy Rupa Publications, India